SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #30 · JOB LOSS AND SETBACKS

“One setback means I've ruined my life.”

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Where it often comes from

A single event, such as a failed business, a layoff, a lost promotion, or a bad financial decision, can feel like proof that everything is ruined. This is especially strong when we have worked hard to avoid mistakes. Perfectionism, a family that punished failure, or a past experience in which one mistake had large consequences can make every setback feel final.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him. Joseph told his brothers that what they intended for evil, God intended for good. Paul says we are persecuted but not forsaken, struck down but not destroyed. God said, “Do not call to mind the former things,” and “Behold, I am about to do something new.” These verses do not call a setback good. They say that it is not the last word, and that God can bring something out of it that we cannot yet see.

> *“And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose”* (Romans 8:28).

Also see

> “As for you, what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good, in order to accomplish a day like this—to preserve the lives of many people” (Genesis 50:20).

> “‘Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.’” (Isaiah 43:18–19).

> “Persecuted, but not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed” (2 Corinthians 4:9).

> “Do not gloat over me, my enemy! Though I have fallen, I will arise; though I sit in darkness, the LORD will be my light” (Micah 7:8).

Common self-statements

- I ruined everything.
- There is no coming back from this.
- My whole life is wrecked.
- I blew my one chance.
- Everything I built is gone.
- One mistake has defined me.

Common logical errors

- Catastrophizing: Turning one event into total ruin.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing life as either perfect or ruined.
- Overgeneralizing: Treating one setback as a pattern for my whole life.
- Mental filter: Seeing only the damage and missing what remains.

Challenging questions

- What exactly was lost, and what is still here?
- Has anyone I admire had a major setback and gone on to good things?
- What did I learn that I could not have learned another way?
- What parts of my life are untouched by this?
- What might God be doing that I cannot yet see?
- What is one thing I can rebuild first?

Truth summary

> A setback is real, but it is not my whole life. God can work through hard things, and nothing is wasted in His hands. I can grieve what was lost, keep what remains, and begin again.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Hardship
- Hopeless
- Suffering
- Trust
- Plans

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Even If — MercyMe
Trust in God need not depend on receiving the particular miracle we want.

Victory in Jesus — Joy Gardner, Cynthia Clawson, Mike Allen and Reggie Smith
This classic gospel hymn celebrates Christ's rescue and the hope of life with Him.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "One setback means I've ruined my life"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"One setback means I've ruined my life." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What was lost and what remains?
- ☐ What did I learn?
- ☐ What parts of my life are untouched?
- ☐ Who has come back from a setback?
- ☐ What is one thing to rebuild first?
- ☐ Where am I catastrophizing?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ A setback is not a ruined life.
- ☐ God works all things together for good.
- ☐ I can begin again.
- ☐ What remains is worth building on.
- ☐ I do not have to see the whole plan.
- ☐ One chapter is not the whole book.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Romans 8:28**
  "And we know that God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose."
- ☐ **Genesis 50:20**
  "As for you, what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good, in order to accomplish a day like this—to preserve the lives of many people."
- ☐ **Isaiah 43:18–19**
  "'Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Lost and left: Each week, list one thing lost and one thing that remains. Notice how the lists compare.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 8:28 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God works all things together for good, so this setback is not the end of my story.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Hardship" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Make two lists. Write what was lost and what remains. Include people, skills, faith, and health.
- [ ] Name what you learned. Write two lessons you can take forward.
- [ ] Choose one thing to rebuild. Pick one area and take one small action this week.
- [ ] Share the story. Tell a trusted friend what happened and what you hope to do next.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "One setback means I've ruined my life": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	What remains
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~One setback means I've ruined my life.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, this setback feels huge. Remind me that it is not the end of my story. Work in this for good, show me what remains, and give me courage to begin again. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.